Qualitative Research is a Valuable Part of Computer Science Research at TU Delft

Members of Computer Science at TU Delft

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We base this document on the following definition of *Qualitative Research*:

> "*Qualitative Research* gathers participants' experiences, perceptions, and behavior. It answers the hows and whys (...). At its core, [it] asks open-ended questions whose answers are not easily put into numbers (...)."[1]

It uses data collection methods such as:

- interviews, focus groups
- observations
- contextual inquiry
- document analysis
- participant observation

It uses data analysis methods and tools such as:

- coding
- thematic analysis
- content analysis
- constant comparison
- Atlas.ti, MAXQDA

We, the signers, are concerned that the use, execution, and evaluation of qualitative methods are judged unfairly or harshly in both education and research. Therefore, by signing this document, making it public, and discussing it actively in our departments, we aim to achieve the following:

1. Acknowledge qualitative research methods as being an integral part of Computer Science, next to other methods. This will alleviate the need to repeatedly justify that qualitative methods are relevant for our students to learn and execute as well as for us to use in our research and supervision.
2. Have qualitative research be judged according to its own benefits, but also challenges. This will acknowledge that the execution of qualitative methods takes different times/resources, comes with a longer review process, and is therefore harder to produce an equal number of publications when compared to quantitative methods. Evaluators on all levels will be just as open to qualitative research as to quantitative research.

We acknowledge that several Computer Science staff members at TU Delft apply qualitative research methods and do not run into problems while doing so. But we also acknowledge that others do face issues and we therefore support these two goals. We believe and advocate for qualitative research as a valuable contribution to computer science research.

Signed by (in alphabetical order): Carolin Brandt, Willem-Paul Brinkman, Jesper Cockx, Stefan Hugtenburg, Hayley Hung, Megha Khosla, Ivo van Kreveld, Cynthia Liem, Christoph Lofi, Jack McKinlay, Odette Scharenborg, Martin Skrodzki, Myrthe Tielman, Julián Urbano

[1] `https://www.ncbi.nlm.nih.gov/books/NBK470395/`